Mehrdad Pourghasem

Fifth-Year PhD Candidate, Economics, Pennsylvania State University

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Available May–August 2027 | Open to relocation

Profile

Fifth-year Economics PhD candidate (expected 2028) in **empirical industrial organization** and **health economics**. I estimate structural demand and bargaining models on large administrative datasets to measure how market structure and physician–insurer integration shape hospital competition—including how standard merger-review demand models mismeasure diversion. Four years of prior applied research experience scoping ambiguous questions and presenting technical findings to non-technical decision-makers.

Education

PhD in Economics, Pennsylvania State University 2022 – 2028 (expected)
Fields: Industrial Organization, Health Economics. Advisors: Conor Ryan, Paul Grieco.
Dissertation: *Who Chooses Your Hospital? Inherited Demand and the Measurement of Hospital Competition.*

MSc in Economics, Sharif University of Technology, Iran 2022
Thesis: *Road Infrastructure and Agricultural Outcomes.* Ranked 1st in cumulative GPA in cohort; top 0.5% of 10,000+ nationwide graduate entrance-exam candidates.

BSc in Industrial Engineering, Sharif University of Technology, Iran 2019

Research

- **Who Chooses Your Hospital? Inherited Demand and the Measurement of Hospital Competition** *(job market paper).* Hospital merger review rests on demand models in which patients choose hospitals. Using **claims covering 8.5 million commercially insured Californians**, I show elective surgical demand is routed by referral menus owned by primary care organizations: menus persist when an organization's physicians are replaced, travel with physicians who switch employer, and reallocate when organizations close. A **consideration-set demand model** places 2.4 of 48 available hospitals on the effective menu. Replaying observed closures, the standard model recovers **41% of measured within-system diversion against 88%** for the menu model—a bias that clears mergers that should be flagged.
- **Heterogeneous Willingness-to-Pay for Electric Vehicles.** Merged market-level auto sales (Ward's), household microdata (CEX), and vehicle attributes; estimated **random-coefficients logit demand (BLP)** with demographic interactions and micro-moments to recover willingness-to-pay and price elasticities by household segment.

Professional Experience

Research Analyst, Morvarid Petrochemical Company, Tehran, Iran Oct 2019 – Dec 2020

- Scoped broad strategic questions with the CEO into a structured analysis plan with defined milestones; led a 4-member team to deliver it.
- Built a dynamic forecasting model linking macroeconomic indicators to output and profitability; ran scenario analyses and presented recommendations to the executive team to guide long-term capital investment.

Research Analyst, Iranian Water Policy Research Institute, Tehran, Iran Oct 2017 – Dec 2018

- Evaluated competing regional water-market designs by combining stakeholder interviews with a structured review of international case studies; quantified the economic impact of alternative allocation rules, documenting assumptions, data sources, and limitations.
- Presented findings to 100+ stakeholders at a multi-day Chamber of Commerce forum, distilling technical analysis into clear options and trade-offs.

Earlier: **Research Analyst**, Urmia Lake Restoration Commission (2017); **Business Analyst**, Smartup Ventures (2016–17) — market research and feasibility analyses for early-stage ventures; promoted to CEO Assistant within six months.

Teaching

Instructor, Penn State — Intro to Macroeconomic Analysis and Policy (enrollment: 38) Summer 2025
Teaching Assistant, Penn State — International Finance; Advanced International Trade 2022 – present

Technical Skills

Programming & Tools: Python (pandas, NumPy, PyBLP), Stata, R, SQL, ArcGIS, Tableau, Power BI, LaTeX | **Languages:** English, Persian

Methods: Structural estimation (consideration-set and BLP demand, Nash-in-Nash bargaining, merger simulation, diversion ratios), causal inference (DiD, IV, event study), panel data, large administrative claims data